5. Abscission

Abscission is a physiological process of shedding of organs like leaves, flowers, fruits and seeds from the parent plant body. When these parts are removed the plant seals off its vascular system to prevent loss of water and nutrients. Final stage of senescence is abscission. In temperate regions all the leaves of deciduous plants fall in autumn and give rise to naked appearance, then the new leaves are developed in the subsequent spring season. But in evergreen plants there is gradual abscission of leaves, the older leaves fall while new leaves are developed continuously throughout the year.

6. Morphological and Anatomical changes during abscission

Leaf abscission takes place at the base of petiole which is marked internally by a distinct zone of few layers of thin walled cells arranged transversely. This zone is called **abscission zone or abscission layer**. An abscission layer is greenish-grey in colour and is formed by rows of cells of 2 to 15 cells thick. The cells of abscission layer separate due to dissolution of middle lamella and primary wall of cells by the activity of enzymes **pectinase** and **cellulase** resulting in loosening of cells. Tyloses are also formed blocking the conducting vessels. Degrading of chlorophyll occur leading to the change in the colour of leaves, leaf detachment from the plant and leaf fall. After abscission, outer layer of cells becomes suberized by the development of periderm (Figure 15.25).

7. Hormones influencing abscission

All naturally occurring hormones influence the process of abscission. Auxins and cytokinins retard abscission, while abscisic acid (ABA) and ethylene induce it.

8. Significance of abscission

1. Abscission separates dead parts of the plant, like old leaves and ripe fruits.
2. It helps in dispersal of fruits and continuing the life cycle of the plant.
3. Abscission of leaves in deciduous plants helps in water conservation during summer.
4. In lower plants, shedding of vegetative parts like gemmae or plantlets help in vegetative reproduction.

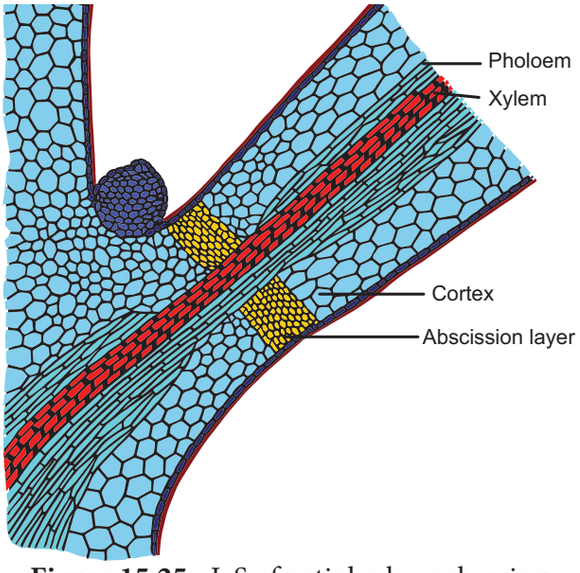


Figure 15.25: L.S of petiolar base showing abscission layer

15.8 Stress Physiology

Like all other organisms, plants are also subjected to various environmental stresses such as water deficit, drought, cold, heat, salinity and air pollution. The study of functioning of plants under adverse environmental conditions is called **stress physiology**. **Jacob Levitt** (1972) first used the term **biological stress** in relation to plants and according to him stress is "any change in environmental condition that might adversely change the growth and development of a plant".

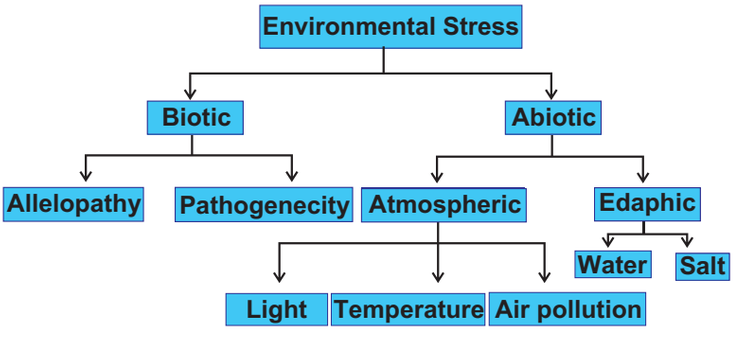


Figure 15.26: Classification of Stress types in plants

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